

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



THE APPROACH IS BAIT-AND-SEE

Among rattiest cities in US, Chicago's 311 rodent calls decrease as some look to more ecologically friendly forms of rat control

By William Tong | Chicago Tribune

Dragging the weighted black bait box out from the brush with his boots, Ryan Campbell wiped a few beads of sweat from his forehead. The 30-year-old service technician for Rose Pest Control was about halfway through his last rodent service call of the day in Ukrainian Village.

He flicked the lid off the bait box, revealing an interior compartment containing dirt, dried leaves and, oddly enough, a blue Lindor chocolate truffle wrapper. Rats bring all sorts of treats into these boxes, which they sometimes use as shelter, he said.

"It's something about seeing all the nasty stuff that people don't see," Campbell said of why he enjoys his job. "And you just got stories."

Chicago has developed a reputation as one of America's rattiest cities, with one pest control company ranking it first for the last nine years. But recent 311 call data suggests Chicago might be making headway in reducing the city's rodent problems.

While the number of rodent complaints to Chicago's 311 call center spiked in 2021 at almost 66,000, that number has decreased in the last three years, to less than 46,000 in 2024.

In the first six months of 2025, the city has received 18,979 rodent 311 complaints. Chicago's rodent control staff also seem to be taking less time to respond to 311 service calls, according to city data. The mean service request completion time decreased from about 11.5 days in 2021 to 5.3 days in 2024.

The decrease in 311 calls shows the city's integrated pest management program is working, said Gloria Pittman, deputy

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Top: Ryan Campbell, a service technician with Rose Pest Solutions, puts poison pellets into a hole leading to a rat burrow in an alley near the 1000 block of North Western Avenue in Chicago on July 1. **TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

'El Chapo' son pleads guilty to drug charges

By Jason Meisner
Chicago Tribune

One of the sons of Joaquín "El Chapo" Guzmán could spend the rest of his life in prison after pleading guilty Friday in federal court in Chicago to helping his father and brothers run the notoriously violent Sinaloa cartel, importing thousands of tons of narcotics into the U.S., bribing public officials and using murder and kidnapping to amass and maintain power.

By pleading guilty, however, Ovidio Guzmán López, 35, has agreed to cooperate with U.S. authorities in any ongoing investigations and testify against his associates in the hopes that prosecutors will recommend a sentence of less than life without parole.

Those details were revealed in a dramatic, 90-minute hearing under tight security at the Dirksen U.S. Courthouse, where Guzmán López pleaded guilty to two counts each of supervising an ongoing criminal enterprise and drug trafficking conspiracy, which were brought in indictments filed both in Chicago and New York.

He's the first El Chapo relative to strike a deal with the government, which is also prosecuting three of his brothers in various jurisdictions.

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INSIDE



CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Honoring a 'great teammate, great leader'

Former White Sox pitcher Mark Buehrle, right, poses with former Sox catcher A.J. Pierzynski on Friday as the team unveiled a statue of Buehrle on the outfield concourse during a pregame ceremony at Rate Field. Former players are back in Chicago this weekend for a reunion honoring the 2005 world champions. **Chicago Sports**

BROADWAY VOTE DELAYED:

A plan to upzone a large stretch of North Broadway in the Edgewater and Uptown neighborhoods has stalled in the City Council amid tense debate and a desire to inform more residents. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

NOT JUST DISNEY NOSTALGIA:

"Beauty and the Beast," playing through Aug. 2 at the Cadillac Palace Theatre in Chicago, delivers lovely music, dazzling costumes and standout choreography to please all ages. **Review in Arts & Living**

CHICAGO PUBLIC SCHOOLS

District lays off nearly 1,500

Enrollment, programming changes cited amid firings that affect 1.8% of teachers

By Kate Armanini and Nell Salzman
Chicago Tribune

Chicago Public Schools announced a second round of summer layoffs Friday, firing 1,458 employees to adjust for enrollment and programming changes.

The layoffs include 432 teachers — representing 1.8% of the teaching staff — including 132 special education teachers. Also affected were 311 paraprofessionals including teaching assistants and school-related personnel, 33 security officers and 677 special education classroom assistants.

CPS evaluates staffing and resource allocation at the start of each school year. But this year's finalization of school-level budgets, or the specific allocation of money to each school, was pushed from June to July amid the district's ongoing fiscal challenges. The district is facing a \$734 million budget deficit, according to interim CEO Macqueline King.

Only 48 more employees were laid off this year than last, a 3.2% increase, the district said in a statement.

"These changes, while necessary to ensure effective allocation of resources, are approached with care and consideration," the statement said. "We recognize that any staffing change can be difficult, and we are committed to supporting our valued employees through this process."

In an interview with Tribune, district Chief Budget Officer Michael Sitkowski and Chief Talent Officer Ben Felton said the layoffs are related to school-level budgets released in May, and do not alleviate the district's budget shortfall. It is unclear if more layoffs could occur in the coming months.

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Cuts deliver blow to State Department

Critics say mass firings will weaken US power globally

By Matthew Lee
Associated Press

KUALA LUMPUR, Malaysia — The U.S. State Department is firing more than 1,300 employees on Friday in line with a dramatic reorganization plan from the Trump administration that critics say will damage America's global leadership and efforts to counter threats abroad.

The department has begun sending layoff notices to 1,107 civil servants and 246 Foreign Service officers with assignments in the United States, according to a senior department official who spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss personnel matters.

Staff began to receive notices shortly after 10 a.m. Friday saying their positions were being "abolished" and that they would be losing access to the department's headquarters in Washington as well as their email and share drives by 5 p.m., according to a copy of one of the notices obtained by The Associated Press.

Foreign Service officers affected will be placed immediately on administrative leave for 120 days, after which they will formally lose their jobs, according to a separate internal notice. For most civil servants, the separation period is 60 days, it said.

"Headcount reductions have been carefully tailored to affect non-core functions, duplicative or redundant offices,"

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